

Theory of Documentation

De charles.hoffman@me.com <charles.hoffman@me.com>

Para 'Peter Rivett' <pete.rivett@federatedknowledge.com>, 'Cory Casanave' <cory-c@modeldriven.com>, 'Mrs. Elisa Kendall' <ekendall@thematix.com>, 'RAYNIER - XBRLCP' <raynier@xbrlcp.com>, 'Andrew Noble' <Andrew@nobleaccounting.com.au>, 'Pierre Hamon' <hamon.pierre@etxetera.com>, 'Claude Baudoin' <claudio@omg.org>, lars.toomre@brcfintech.com, 'Campbell J Pryde' <campbell.pryde@xbrl.us>, 'Jason Meyers' <jm@auditchain.com>, 'David Vun Kannon' <dvunkannon@hotmail.com>, 'Jindrich Kolman' <kolman.jindrich@gmail.com>, edmund_w@mit.edu, 'Richard Beatch' <rbeatch@bloomberg.net>, edmund_w@schuster.us.com, rrobinson57@bloomberg.net, 'Ms. Bobbin Teegarden' <bobbin@ontoage.com>, mark.montoya@gbaglobal.org, bill.seddon@lyquidity.com, pete.rivett@agnos.ai, Nikkyann.Berteau@broadridge.com, 'Юрий Волкович' <war21x3b@gmail.com>, 'Miguel Calejo' <mc@logicalcontracts.com>, hamedmousavi@yahoo.com, 'John Turner' <john.turner@xbrl.org>, dudley.gould@gmail.com, 'Daniel Enrique Montoya Guerrero' <danielmontoya.contacto@gmail.com>, 'Adam Booker' <Adam.Booker@du.edu>, 'Allan Mendelowitz' <amendelowitz@yahoo.com>, 'John Yapundich' <johnyapundich@hotmail.com>, 'Alex Neblett' <alex.neblett@gmail.com>, jmorapedros@gmail.com, pippert_bryce@bah.com, 'Fuad Begic' <fuad.begic@gmail.com>, 'Louis Matherne' <lmatherne@fasb.org>, timothysrandle@gmail.com, 'Dean Ritz' <dean@deanritz.com>, 'Marc Joffe' <marc@publicsectorcredit.org>, chris.kuglin@gmail.com, 'David Blaszkowsky' <blaszkowskyd@gmail.com>, 'Stephen Walker' <stephen.walker@berkeley.edu>, 'Anna Kwok' <anna.kwok@workiva.com>, 'Juan Carlos Rodriguez Rivera' <jcoolcat@gmail.com>, sheridan@fevanalytics.com, nehmer@oakland.edu, pdw@xbrl.org, 'Janis Steinmann' <Janis.Steinmann@amana.de>, raj@transformpartner.com, philip.foster@oxfordsemantic.tech, valerio.cocchi@oxfordsemantic.tech, henrik@jinsei.ai, Philippe Höij <philippe.hoij@dfrnt.com>, 'Alan Morrison' <a.s.morrison@gmail.com>, 'Michael Atkin' <atkin@content-strategies.com>, 'Dave McComb' <mccomb@semanticarts.com>, sander.hoen@visma.com, ljb@tahoebblue.com, 'Philip Oakman' <phil.oakman@auxilis.com.au>, 'David Lau' <david@automa8e.com>, 'Steve Berdah' <sberdah@ubpartner.fr>, dudley.gould@gmail.com, 'Joseph French' <joeey@harbinger.finance>, Jonathan Schmidt <jonathan.schmidt@dfrnt.com>, Richard Gasca <co.auditoria@pm.me>

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Documents and the documentation they contain are the bridge between economic reality and the accounting system representation and interpretation of that reality. Audit and assurance is about making sure the accounting system interpretation is consistent with what regulators specify. Documents and documentation they contain are the first semantic layer in the chain that ultimately produces financial statements, analytics, and compliance reporting.

If this first layer is suboptimal; there is in impact to everything else downstream. Seems like you would want to get that first layer right.

<https://digitalfinancialreporting.blogspot.com/2026/08/theory-of-documentation.html>

Do we really want two versions of source documents when that can be avoided? Understand that a document provides:

- **Evidence:** supporting audit trails and internal controls
- **Structure:** standard forms (invoices, purchase orders, shipping manifests) organize business information consistently
- **Meaning:** standard semantics like SBVR and UBL define shared vocabularies and document models for interoperable business reporting
- **Input to financial statements:** some documents summarize the state of business events (e.g., bank statements, account statements, financial statements) rather than generating new ones
- **Input to financial analysis models:** ultimately all this effort yields the ability to analyze what is going on for various reasons (e.g. management, regulatory compliance, capital allocation)

Have you ever heard of the 1-10-100 rule?

<https://youtu.be/ks8ZUNu7bjs>

Cheers,

Charlie